

Practice Paper 31 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “Worn to the colour of weak tea”

1 mark for understanding that the bean-bag is **faded and well used**; **1 mark** for understanding that this implies the corner has been **loved / used by many children over many years**.

Sample answer: The bean-bag is so **faded** and **worn** that its original colour has dulled to a pale brown, suggesting that **generations of children** have used the corner regularly over a long period of time.

Q2. [2] — “Vanished without ceremony”

1 mark for understanding that the closure is **unmarked / without recognition**; **1 mark** for the contrast — twenty-one years of service deserved **more acknowledgement** than this quiet ending.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the closure is happening **quietly and without any formal recognition**, even though something that had served the community for twenty-one years arguably deserved a **more dignified or public farewell**.

Q3. [2] — “Polite, blameless syntax”

1 mark — The notice uses **neutral, official language** that thanks borrowers but **avoids assigning responsibility** for the closure.

1 mark — This troubles the narrator because the wording **evades accountability** — no person or institution is named as the one who has chosen to shut the library down, even though the decision was someone’s to make.

Q4. [2] — “The bones of the place”

1 mark — **Metaphor:** describing the empty library as “bones” suggests the building has been **stripped down** to its bare structure, the way a skeleton is what remains after the flesh is gone.

1 mark — **Effect:** it makes the library feel **lifeless** / **dead** / a **remains** of what was once living, which is a powerful image of loss.

Q5. [2] — Shelving the book

(a) [1]: It reveals her **deep professionalism** / **care for the work** / **quiet integrity** — she follows the proper procedure even when no one is watching.

(b) [1]: She means that acting **properly and with care** is largely something one does **for one's own sense of self-respect**, not because anyone else will see or judge it.

Q6. [3] — “A small ache to my throat” (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the language conveys **suppressed emotion** / **the threat of tears**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “the spelling brought a small ache to my throat” — the **physical sensation** of an ache in the throat is the body's response to **holding back tears**.
- “the sort of paper a child uses when adults are not looking” — suggests **tenderness** and **innocence**, which is what moves her.
- “feint-ruled, slightly torn” — the small, careful detail makes the child's letter feel **vulnerable** and **real**.
- “of a kind I had not been expecting” — she is **caught off guard** by the depth of her own feeling.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — Yusuf's post-script

1 mark — It suggests that Yusuf is **thoughtful** and **honest**: he has decided not to keep the book but to return it, even though it is his favourite.

1 mark — It also suggests he is **sincere** / **innocent** — he means every word, and treats the librarian's question of return as a serious moral matter (even though the library is closing).

Q8. [1] — “Ceased to be a library”

1 mark — She feels that the building's **identity** / **purpose** depended on its function: the moment she shelved a book in a place that no longer had a children's shelf, the building had become **just a building**, no longer truly a library. (Accept: she recognises that the library **lives in its use**, not in its walls.)

Q9. [1] — Evidence of composure

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- She “folded it again, along its original creases” — a careful, controlled action.
- She decides she “would not, on any account, tell him that I had cried”.
- She slips the letter into her pocket rather than continuing to dwell on it.

Q10. [2] — “Weighed almost nothing at all”

1 mark — **Literally**, the letter is light — a single sheet of paper has almost no physical weight.

1 mark — **Figuratively**, the contrast is striking: the letter weighs **nothing** in her pocket but carries **enormous emotional significance** for her — it is, in a sense, the only thing she is leaving the library with.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final paragraph

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly reflective, dignified, subdued, bittersweet, understated**.
(Reject: **cheerful, angry, bitter** — these miss the restrained quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “With a straight face”

1 mark for understanding that “**epidemic**” once seemed an exaggerated or alarmist word in this context.

1 mark for understanding that the situation is now **so severe** that officials use the word **without irony or hesitation** — it is taken seriously as a public health issue.

Q13. [2] — “Paradoxical setting”

1 mark — A **paradox** is a contradiction or apparent inconsistency.

1 mark — The contradiction is that young adults are **constantly in contact** through phones and social media, yet **feel deeply isolated** — high contact and high loneliness exist at the same time.

Q14. [1] — “Depth fallen through the floor”

1 mark — He means that although young people communicate **frequently**, the **quality / closeness** of their relationships has collapsed dramatically — they have many acquaintances but no genuinely close friends.

Q15. [2] — “Third place” (own words)

1 mark — A setting that is **neither one’s home nor one’s place of work or study**.

1 mark — It is somewhere one can have **informal, unplanned conversations** with people one has not deliberately chosen — a public, social space.

Q16. [2] — Why third places have disappeared

1 mark each for any two of:

- Many such places have **closed down** entirely.
- They have become **too expensive** for ordinary use.
- They have been **displaced** by businesses that **prefer customers not to linger** / want quick turnover.

Q17. [2] — “Slow, low-stakes companionship”

1 mark — **Effect:** the phrase captures the **unforced, easy** nature of these office interactions — they are **not dramatic friendships** but small, daily contacts that build up over time.

1 mark — **Low-stakes** emphasises that they involve **no commitment or pressure** — and it is precisely this **casual quality** that makes them so valuable and so easily lost.

Q18. [2] — “This is not a metaphor. It is a clinical fact.”

1 mark — The **short, blunt sentences** contrast with the more flowing earlier prose and signal a **shift in tone** — from description to direct assertion.

1 mark — They **forestall** the reader’s likely scepticism — that the writer is speaking **figura-**

tively about the body “breaking down” — and insist that the harm is **physical and medically measurable**.

Q19. [1] — Tone of “uncomfortably like dating apps”

1 mark — **Wry / dryly humorous / gently ironic**. (Also accept: **amused, bemused**. Reject: **sarcastic, mocking** — these are too harsh.)

Q20. [2] — Old-fashioned remedies

1 mark each for any two of: **running clubs, choirs, board-game nights, weekly walks with a neighbour**.

Q21. [2] — “The trouble is no longer a quiet one”

1 mark — **Effect**: the short, declarative sentence is **emphatic**, providing a **firm conclusion** to the article.

1 mark — It **echoes and inverts** the opening image of loneliness as the “quiet trouble of the elderly”, signalling that this is no longer a small or private issue but a **loud, public, urgent** one that society must confront.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Causes of chronic loneliness (Paragraphs 3–5):

1. The **disappearance of “third places”** — informal public spaces other than home and work.
2. Such places have **closed**, become **too expensive**, or been **replaced by businesses** that discourage lingering.
3. **Remote and hybrid work** have removed the **small, daily, unplanned interactions** of an office.
4. Workplace friendships, **historically** a source of mid-life companionship, are now **harder to form**.
5. **Health consequences** — raised cortisol, fragmented sleep, **cardiovascular risk** on a par with heavy smoking — make the problem urgent.

Responses being attempted (Paragraph 6):

6. **Employers** are mandating in-office days, funding retreats and, occasionally, paying for therapy.
7. **Schools and universities** are running structured friendship interventions for lonely students.
8. **Individuals** are returning to traditional social activities — clubs, choirs, board-game nights, neighbourhood walks — and finding that they work.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Young adults today are lonely partly because the casual public spaces between home and work have closed, become unaffordable, or been replaced by venues that discourage lingering. Remote working has also stripped away small, daily office contacts, making workplace friendships harder to form. The resulting isolation harms sleep, hormones and the heart. In response, employers are bringing staff back together, schools are arranging structured introductions, and individuals are rediscovering clubs, choirs and weekly walks with neighbours.

Length count: 78 words from “Young” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —